be settled at a later date, but at least get on with it. Though the talks involved all the stakeholders, the notable omission was the Army/AR who would actually be at the forefront of implementing any accord. This hesitation to involve the Army in the negotiations and decision-making process in the overall security architecture of the nation always has been, and remains, a mystery.

Having served in all the Corps of the Command, it was relatively easier for me to re-familiarize myself with the terrain and tasks of the Corps and Divisions. I made it a point to visit those areas I had not been to earlier; Naku La in Sikkim for instance, and Yangste in the Tawang Sector. These were the two areas that used to have regular violent face-offs. While we were in an advantageous position at Yangste, the same was not true for Naku La. During our visits to Naku La in North Sikkim, the Corps Commander, Lt Gen Mohanty, and I, along with the local commanders, would brainstorm ways to become more effective. The bottom line would invariably be for at least two Companies of Infantry to be given from either of the Brigades of 20 Mountain Division at Binaguri. Binaguri was a peace station and I felt it would be unfair to those units to again redeploy in field, that too in HAA. On the other hand, there was a mechanized Infantry Battalion in the forward area of North Sikkim itself, which was not being taken into account. Apparently, the fact that they were Infantry had been lost sight of, or that the ICVs were just another mode of transportation. When I suggested that these Companies that were readily available in situ be utilized, there was some initial hesitation, as if I had suggested something strange. After the idea sank in, the Companies of the mechanized Battalion were utilized sans their ICVs, in a purely Infantry role and they performed splendidly. The men just have to be given an

Copyright @ Penguin Random House India
Not for circulation